# 1.3 Controversies About the Articles

Have you ever thought of a brilliant solution to a problem that only led to more problems? In the 1780s, the Articles of Confederation were exactly that: a solution that led to more problems.

**MAIN IDEA** The Articles of Confederation limited the federal government's effectiveness and led to economic problems and challenges to its authority.

## THE PRICE OF WAR

The Articles of Confederation provided a governing structure during the Revolution but quickly proved inadequate for the needs of the new nation. The Articles created 13 sovereign states instead of one unified nation. So when the national government faced growing economic problems, it did not have an effective system in place to solve them.

One economic problem was the amount of debt that remained after the Revolution. By 1790, the U.S. government owed around $50 million to American merchants and farmers and also to the French government. The shortfall in funds also meant soldiers could not be paid, which led to angry protests.

Because of the limitations of the Articles, Congress could not impose taxes or regulate trade. Individual states refused to contribute enough money to help the national government pay these debts. Rewriting the Articles so that Congress could levy taxes was nearly impossible because the representatives of all 13 states had to approve such a measure. Few, if any, states were likely to offer their support, so the debts went unpaid.

Before the war, many Americans relied on receiving **credit**, or the privilege of purchasing something and paying the cost back over time. British companies wanted to encourage the colonists to buy their goods, and giving credit made that possible. As British subjects, farmers could repay their debts with goods, such as livestock and crops. After the war, British manufacturers demanded that all debts be repaid with money instead of goods. At the same time, state governments started to impose heavy taxes upon their citizens. Few farmers had cash on



Tricorn hat

**Memorial Hall Museum**
**Deerfield, Massachusetts**

Tricorn hats like this one, dated 1775, were popular in Europe and America in the 1700s. Notice how the tricorn hat appears in the illustration on the opposite page, flying off the head of the man attacking the official. Other men in the scene are wearing tricorn hats as well.



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hand, and many Americans, especially farmers, faced financial ruin. When farmers failed to repay their debts, they often faced prosecution and the loss of their farms.

In some states, those who owed money demanded new laws that would allow them to settle their debts and pay taxes with goods. Citizens also wanted fewer requirements for voting so that they would have better representation in state governments. When governments did not respond, citizens challenged their authority and legitimacy by rebelling.

## SHAYS'S REBELLION

In the fall of 1786, Daniel Shays, a veteran of the American Revolution, led rifle-carrying farmers into various Massachusetts courthouses and demanded the end of debt hearings. The Massachusetts government frantically asked Congress for help to put down the armed rebellion. In turn, Congress requested that the states help by sending money and soldiers, but the states refused. Its inability to respond to the domestic crisis of citizen rebellion revealed how ineffective Congress was under the Articles of Confederation.

Citizens became angrier when the state of Massachusetts passed the Riot Act, which prohibited armed groups from gathering in public. To prove its point, the state government sent armed troops, who defeated Shays's men easily. Shays and his supporters risked losing their voting rights and even imprisonment. However, **Shays's Rebellion** inspired other people to stand up to the government. One effect of the uprising was that in the following year's election, voter participation increased dramatically. Citizens wanted input into how problems such as debt repayment could be resolved.



**CRITICAL VIEWING** A protestor attacks an official during Shays's Rebellion in an attempt to disrupt court proceedings in Springfield, Massachusetts. Protests over the repayment of debts occurred in many states but reached a higher level of intensity in Massachusetts. Confrontations between farmers and government officials also occurred in the Massachusetts towns of Northampton, Concord, and Worcester. What details in the illustration convey the drama of Shays's Rebellion?

### HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the Articles of Confederation limit the effectiveness of the federal government?
2. **DETERMINE CHRONOLOGY** In what ways did the economics of the American Revolution lead to Shays's Rebellion?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What effect did Shays's Rebellion have on the election of 1787?



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